

The Shadow in the Hall

A hunting encounter in the lower halls of the Ember Keep. Something that survived the War of Embers has been here for three centuries, and it does not welcome visitors.

READ ALOUD WHEN THE PARTY DESCENDS

The stair ends in a hall longer than the keep above it should allow. Your light reaches perhaps twenty feet and then simply stops, as though the dark past it were something solid that has agreed, for now, to let you look.

There is no sound. Not the marsh, not the wind through the broken towers, not the water you have been listening to since the causeway. Only the flagstones, swept clean of three hundred years of dust in a wide path down the middle of the hall — and the understanding, arriving all at once, that something has been using this corridor, and that it stopped moving when you did.

Setting the Scene

The party enters the lower halls and realises they are not alone. The Lurker moves faster in complete darkness and knows the keep's layout better than any map the party carries. It has been waiting — not for them specifically, but for anyone, for a very long time.

The hall runs eighty feet to a collapsed archway, with three side passages that cannot be seen from the stair. The Lurker uses all of them. It will not attack from the front while a light source burns; it circles, snuffs, and takes the rearmost character first.

Beyond the archway is the sealed library door and its puzzle lock, unopened for three centuries. The Lurker will not let the party reach it on this visit, and that refusal is the most useful thing they can learn here.

Running the Hunt

LIGHT IS THE WHOLE FIGHT

Track every light source explicitly and say aloud when one is threatened. The Lurker's first action in combat is always to extinguish the brightest flame within reach — *Smothering Dark* is as much a light-eater as an attack. Torches gutter; magical light dims by one step for a round.

If the party holds a single bottleneck with light at both ends, let that work. Rewarding the tactic is better than protecting the monster.

IF THE PARTY HAS NO LIGHT

The Lurker attacks with advantage and its speed rises to 60 ft. It will separate one character from the group and drive them toward the sealed library door rather than kill outright — it herds before it feeds.

THE NAME THAT STOPS IT

The Lurker was an archivist of the Order of Embers. It cannot speak, but it remembers the name **Ashvale**. Spoken aloud — by Mira, or by anyone who learned it from her — the creature halts for one full round, forfeits its legendary actions that round, and will not attack that speaker again until it is attacked itself.

This lands hardest if the party has already sat with Mira at her camp on the western approach, or pressed Aldric Vane about the expedition he will not discuss. Play the pause long. A monster that stops to listen is a different story than a monster that dies.

THREE WAYS THIS ENDS

Any of them is a success. The encounter exists to make the lower halls frightening and the library door important, not to spend hit points.

- **They kill it.** It collapses into the dark and re-forms at the library door in seven days, older and more careful.
- **They name it.** The hesitation holds. It withdraws to the archway and watches them leave — and it is still watching the next time they come down.
- **They run.** *Seal-Bound* means it cannot follow past the stair. It will be at the bottom step when they return.

The Lurker

Medium aberration (formerly human), unaligned

ARMOUR CLASS 15 (unnatural hide)

HIT POINTS 68 (8d8 + 32)

SPEED 40 ft., 60 ft. in total darkness

SKILLS Stealth +8, Perception +6

SENSES blindsight 60 ft., passive Perception 16

LANGUAGES understands Common, cannot speak

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	18 (+4)	18 (+4)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	6 (−2)

Traits

Darkness Sense. It sees without light and moves faster where there is none. In total darkness its attacks are made with advantage.

Silent Movement. It makes no sound at all until it chooses to. Passive Perception never detects it; an active check is always required.

Seal-Bound. It cannot leave the lower halls. Reduced to 0 hit points, it collapses into the dark and re-forms at the library door in seven days.

Actions

Raking Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 10 (2d6 + 3) slashing damage.

Smothering Dark (Recharge 4–6). Every creature within 10 ft. is blinded until the end of its next turn. Unprotected flames within that radius go out.

Lore

A former archivist of the Order of Embers, transformed as the library's containment seals failed slowly across three hundred years. It recognises the Ashvale family name and will hesitate when it hears it.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS □ □

Fighting in the Dark

ROUND-BY-ROUND, IF YOU NEED A SPINE

ROUND THE LURKER DOES

1	Stays unseen. Snuffs the brightest light with <i>Smothering Dark</i> from outside the party's vision.
2	Strikes the rearmost character, then withdraws into a side passage.
3	Circles to the opposite passage. Attacks whoever relit a flame.
4+	Presses only while half the hall is dark. Below 20 hit points, retreats.

Spoils of the Hall

- A **stone tablet fragment** bearing partial puzzle-lock notation — unintelligible without the other fragments, and proof the lock can be read at all.
- A **sealed vial** labelled in the Order's script. Aldric Vane recognises it on sight and will not explain how.

THREADS TO PULL AFTERWARD

- Mira knew the hall was swept clean. She did not mention it.
- The vial's label names a containment ward — the same script as the carved warnings on the outer wall.
- Whatever Aldric's expedition found four years ago, it was not the library.

Afterward

However the hunt ends, the party climbs out of the lower halls knowing two things they did not know at the stair: the seal on the library is failing, and someone from Thornhaven has been down here before them.

If they named it, add one more: something in the keep remembers a family still living in the village.

Scene & Sound

Run the hall on the **Lower Halls** scene — dripping stone, no music. Cut it the moment the first light goes out.